for reuse. **Erythropoietin** is a hormone secreted by the kidneys in response to low oxygen and helps in differentiation of stem cells of the bone marrow to erythrocytes (erythropoiesis) in adults. The ratio of red blood cells to blood plasma is expressed as **Haematocrit** (packed cell volume).

White blood cells (leucocytes) are colourless, amoeboid, nucleated cells devoid of haemoglobin and other pigments. Approximately 6000 to 8000 per cubic mm of WBCs are seen in the blood of an average healthy individual. The different types of WBCs are shown in Figure 7.2. Depending on the presence or absence of granules, WBCs are divided into two types, **granulocytes** and **agranulocytes**. Granulocytes are characterised by the presence of granules in the cytoplasm and are differentiated in the bone marrow. The granulocytes include **neutrophils, eosinophils and basophils**.

Neutrophils are also called heterophils or polymorphonuclear (cells with 3-4 lobes of nucleus connected with delicate threads) cells which constitute about 60%-65% of the total WBCs. They are phagocytic in nature and appear in large numbers in and around the infected tissues.

Eosinophils have distinctly bilobed nucleus and the lobes are joined by thin strands. They are non-phagocytic and constitute about 2-3% of the total WBCs. Eosinophils increase during certain types of parasitic infections and allergic reactions.

Basophils are less numerous than any other type of WBCs constituting 0.5%-1.0% of the total number of leucocytes. The cytoplasmic granules are large sized, but fewer than eosinophils. Nucleus is large sized and constricted into several lobes but not joined by delicate threads. Basophils secrete substances such as heparin, serotonin and histamines. They are also involved in inflammatory reactions.

Agranulocytes are characterised by the absence of granules in the cytoplasm and are differentiated in the lymph glands and spleen. These are of two types, **lymphocytes** and **monocytes**. Lymphocytes constitute 28% of WBCs. These have large round nucleus and small amount of cytoplasm. The two types of lymphocytes are B and T cells. Both B and T cells are responsible for the immune responses of the body. B cells produce antibodies to neutralize the harmful effects of foreign substances and T cells are involved in cell mediated immunity.

Monocytes (Macrophages) are phagocytic cells that are similar to mast

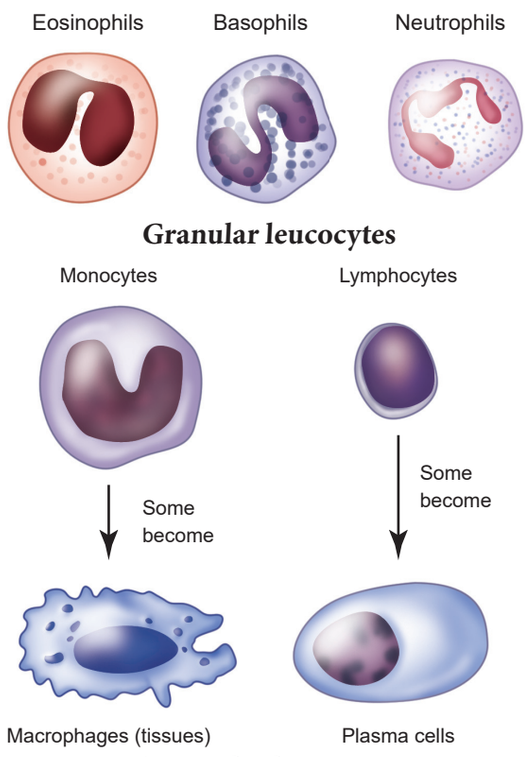


Figure 7.2 Different types of WBC

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